AI CONFERENCE 2026 | F1-THEMED TEAM COMPETITION

HACKATHON ROUND BRIEFING

THREE ROUNDS | TEAMS OF 4 | TOP 5 REACH THE FINAL BUILD RACE

AT A GLANCE: Three rounds. After Round 2, the top 5 teams advance. After Round 3, every team receives exactly 2 minutes to pitch what it has made.

1. Base instructions

Each team has exactly four students and stays together throughout the competition. Round 1 is individual; Round 2 and Round 3 are collaborative team stages.

Devices: Each participating team is only permitted to bring a maximum of two devices.

Tools and preparation: Teams are expected to come prepared with the coding and AI tools needed for Round 3. Only free AI tools may be used; paid AI tools are prohibited. For example, participants may use VS Code with an AI assistant available on a free plan. Internet access is permitted in Round 3 for tools and documentation.

AI-use rules: AI and AI-generated content/code are prohibited in Rounds 1 and 2. In Round 3, AI-assisted vibe coding is allowed using free AI tools only. Failure to follow these rules results in team disqualification.

2. Hackathon overview

All participating teams begin together. The event runs through three rounds, followed by team pitches. Round-specific instructions and materials are issued at the start of each round; transitions are directed by the organizing team.

Stage	Timing	What participants do
Opening briefing	Before Round 1	The general rules, team instructions and materials are issued at the start of each stage.
Round 1: Technical Qualifier	15 minutes exactly	Complete and submit a question paper independently. Collaboration and AI use are prohibited.
Round 2: Team Challenge	30 minutes	The task, all required resources, and instructions are provided on event day. Work together to complete the task and submit the required response. The use of AI is prohibited.
Qualification results	After Round 2	Round 1 and Round 2 results are combined. The **top five teams** advance; all others are eliminated. Qualifying order sets the final starting grid.
Round 3: Final Build Race	90 minutes total	Use the first 20 minutes to plan and submit the plan to the lead/coordinator. Coding may begin only after submission; **use free AI tools only.**
Team pitches	Immediately after Round 3; exactly 2 minutes per team	Each team pitches what it has made. Every team gets exactly **two minutes.**
Final judging	After pitches	Judges assess the submitted work and the team pitch.

3. Detailed instructions by round

Round 1 — AI & Coding Qualifier | 15 minutes

Each participant will receive a question paper and must complete it independently. It covers general AI concepts, coding logic, and problem-solving. No collaboration and no AI are allowed.

Round 2 — Team Challenge | 30 minutes

The task, all resources required for it, and the instructions will be provided on the day of the event. Work with your team to complete the task and submit the required response within the announced time. AI is strictly prohibited throughout this round.

Round 3 — Final Build Race | 90 minutes

The top 5 teams based on the cumulative scores from Rounds 1 and 2 will move on to the next stage. The teams must build and test a working application using the instructions issued at the start of the round. The first 20 minutes constitute the Safety Car planning phase. During this time, teams must outline the project structure, main screens or sections, core features, and user flow. Submit the initial plan to the lead or coordinator when the 20 minutes are up; coding can begin only after submission. Follow the submitted plan through to the finished project.

AI-assisted vibe coding is allowed during Round 3, but only free AI tools may be used; paid AI tools are prohibited. Coding or no-code tools and internet access for tools/documentation are permitted.

Optional DRS — halfway through the 90-minute Final Build Race: An optional bonus task is announced when the window opens. Teams may attempt it or continue with their planned build. No task details are provided in advance.

Final submission: All submissions must be completed by the deadline, at which point the shared team folder will be locked. Include (1) the working project as a zip file, (2) any output requested in the Round 3 instructions, and (3) a one-page Race Summary.

Team pitch: Immediately after Round 3, each team pitches what it has made. Every team gets exactly 2 minutes.

4. Judging & penalties

Qualification: Round 1 and Round 2 results are combined to rank teams after Round 2. The top 5 advance; all others are eliminated.

Final judging: The Round 3 project, required output, and each team's 2-minute pitch is scored using the 100-point rubric below. There is no separate live demo.

Rule	What to know
AI-use violation	Any failure to follow the round-by-round AI rules results in team disqualification.
Late or missed checkpoint / submission	Yellow Flag: 10% deduction from that team's final score.
Pre-built code or plagiarism	Black Flag: Disqualification if pre-built code or plagiarism is detected during scrutineering.

Late or missed checkpoints, including the initial plan deadline, are subject to the Yellow Flag penalty. Race Control instructions and deadlines apply throughout the event.

Judging rubric criteria

This 100-point rubric applies to the Final Build Race project, required output, and pitch. Round 1 and Round 2 results are combined for qualification after Round 2.

Criterion	What judges assess	Points
Alignment with the submitted plan	How closely the final project matches the team's 20-minute plan.	30
Functionality and completeness	Whether the project works reliably and includes the required features specified prior to the round.	35
Usability and clarity	How easily users can understand and navigate the project.	20
Two-minute pitch	How clearly the team explains its work within exactly 2 minutes.	15
TOTAL	**Final Build Race score**	**100**